

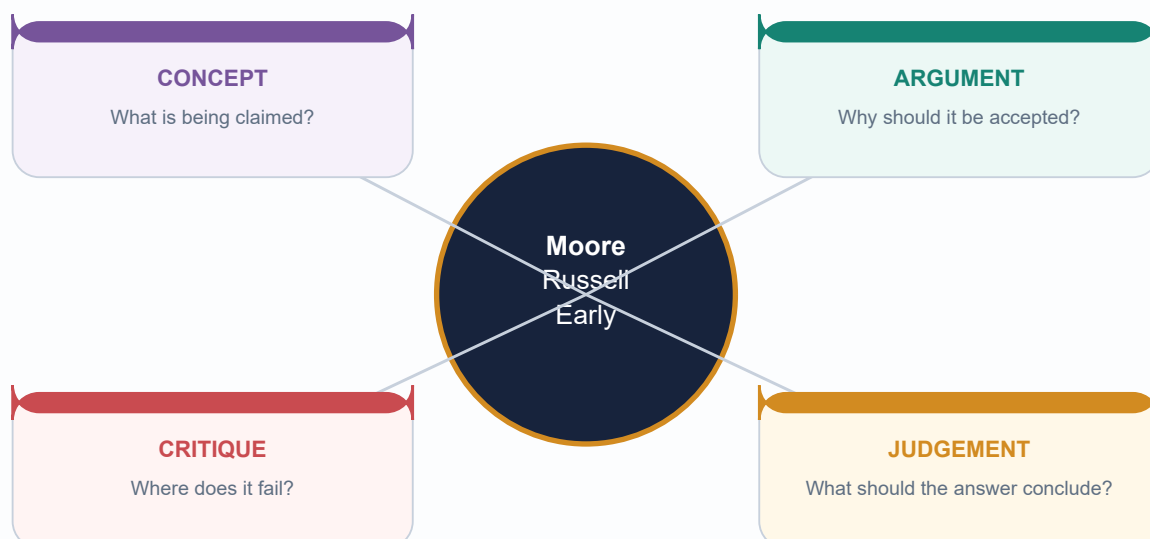
UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

Moore, Russell and Early Wittgenstein — Complete Visual Notes

UPSC Philosophy Optional • Paper I • Western Philosophy

Syllabus: Defence of Commonsense and Refutation of Idealism; Logical Atomism; Logical Constructions; Incomplete Symbols; Theory of Descriptions; Picture Theory of Meaning; Saying and Showing.

Direct local-book analysis • Verified knowledge cross-check • PYQ-mapped answer writing



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Master Map, Context and Technical Vocabulary

Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The analytic turn replaces idealist system-building with common-sense realism and logical analysis, culminating in the Tractarian attempt to display the logical form shared by proposition and fact.

Direct local reading: Kenny, New History vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

TIMELINE

- 1903** — Moore's refutation of idealism and Principia Ethica
- 1905** — Russell publishes On Denoting
- 1918** — Russell lectures on logical atomism
- 1921/22** — Tractatus presents picture theory and saying/showing

WHOLE-TOPIC DOCTRINE MAP

MOORE, RUSSELL AND EARLY WITTGENSTEIN

Moore Common-sense truisms and consciousness distinct from object	Russell Analysis, descriptions, incomplete symbols and atomism
Early Wittgenstein Facts, pictures, logical form and limits of saying	Shared turn Language and analysis replace Absolute idealism

KEY DATA

Term	Precise Meaning	Answer Use
Truism	Common-sense proposition known with greater certainty than sceptical premises	Moore questions
Incomplete symbol	Expression eliminated through contextual definition	Descriptions and constructions
Logical atomism	World analysed into atomic facts and constituents	Russell's metaphysics
Logical form	Structure shared by proposition and possible fact	Picture theory
Showing	What cannot be stated but is displayed in meaningful use	Limits of language

STATIC THEORY

- **Syllabus coverage:** Defence of Commonsense and Refutation of Idealism; Logical Atomism; Logical Constructions; Incomplete Symbols; Theory of Descriptions; Picture Theory of Meaning; Saying and Showing.
- **Intellectual context:** The analytic turn replaces idealist system-building with common-sense realism and logical analysis, culminating in the Tractarian attempt to display the logical form shared by proposition and fact.
- **Source discipline:** claims were reconciled with the verified topic note, recent PYQs and the directly read local books listed below.
- **Theme cross-check:** substance, a priori knowledge and critiques of metaphysics were checked where relevant.

MEMORY HOOK

M-R-W: Moore restores the world; Russell analyses it; Wittgenstein pictures its logical form.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Define each technical term before evaluating it.
2. Reconstruct the internal argument, not merely the conclusion.
3. Distinguish the thinker's own doctrine from a later label or criticism.
4. Use comparisons only after identifying the shared philosophical problem.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Moore proves each truism deductively.

CORRECT: He treats them as more certain than philosophical denials.

WRONG: A description names a special object.

CORRECT: Russell analyses it quantificationally as an incomplete symbol.

WRONG: A picture resembles a fact visually.

CORRECT: It shares logical form, not pictorial appearance.

CROSS-SYLLABUS CONCEPT LINKS

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Common sense	Strawson	Both respect ordinary conceptual commitments differently
Descriptions	Strawson	Reference and presupposition challenge Russell
Picture theory	Later Wittgenstein	Ideal logical form gives way to use
Atomism	Logical positivism	Influences the analytic–synthetic and verification programme

MAINS ANGLE

Open with the problem that generates the doctrine; end by judging its explanatory gain against its strongest internal cost.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Kenny, *New History* vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

HIGH

1. MOORE — Defence of Commonsense & Refutation of Idealism

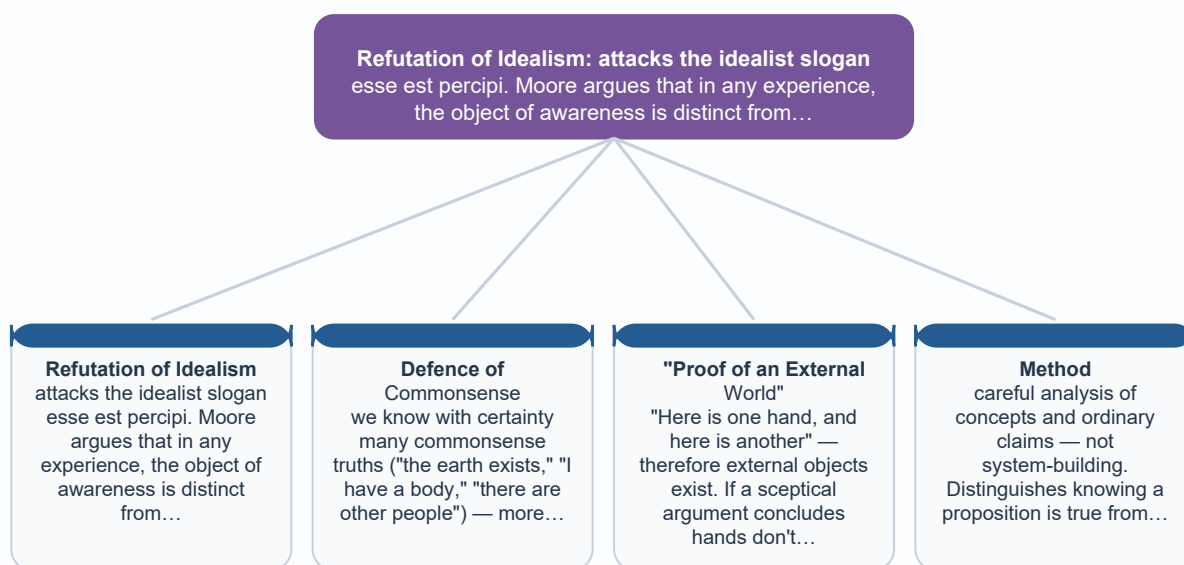
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Refutation of Idealism: attacks the idealist slogan *esse est percipi*. Moore argues that in any experience, the object of awareness is distinct from the act of awareness — "blue" is not the same as the "sensation of blue." Consciousness is diaphanous/transparent; it reveals objects that exist independently of it. → realism restored.

Direct local reading: Kenny, New History vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

1. MOORE — DEFENCE OF COMMONSENSE & REFUTATION OF IDEALISM — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE



STATIC THEORY

- Refutation of Idealism: attacks the idealist slogan *esse est percipi*. Moore argues that in any experience, the object of awareness is distinct from the act of awareness — "blue" is not the same as the "sensation of blue." Consciousness is diaphanous/transparent; it reveals objects that exist independently of it. → realism restored.
- Defence of Commonsense: we know with certainty many commonsense truths ("the earth exists," "I have a body," "there are other people") — more certainly than we know any philosophical premise that would deny them.
- "Proof of an External World": "Here is one hand, and here is another" — therefore external objects exist. If a sceptical argument concludes hands don't exist, it is more reasonable to doubt the argument's premises than to doubt that I have hands.
- Method: careful analysis of concepts and ordinary claims — not system-building. Distinguishes knowing a proposition is true from knowing its correct analysis.

MEMORY HOOK

M-R-W: Moore restores the world; Russell analyses it; Wittgenstein pictures its logical form.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Refutation of Idealism: attacks the idealist slogan *esse est percipi*. Moore argues that in any experience, the object of awareness is distinct from the act of awareness — "blue" is not the same as the "sensation of..."
2. Defence of Commonsense: we know with certainty many commonsense truths ("the earth exists," "I have a body," "there are other people") — more certainly than we know any philosophical premise that would deny them.
3. "Proof of an External World": "Here is one hand, and here is another" — therefore external objects exist. If a sceptical argument concludes hands don't exist, it is more reasonable to doubt the argument's premises...
4. Method: careful analysis of concepts and ordinary claims — not system-building. Distinguishes knowing a proposition is true from knowing its correct analysis.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Moore proves each truism deductively.

CORRECT: He treats them as more certain than philosophical denials.

WRONG: A description names a special object.

CORRECT: Russell analyses it quantificationally as an incomplete symbol.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Kenny, *New History* vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

HIGH

2. RUSSELL — Logical Atomism, Descriptions, Constructions — Part 1

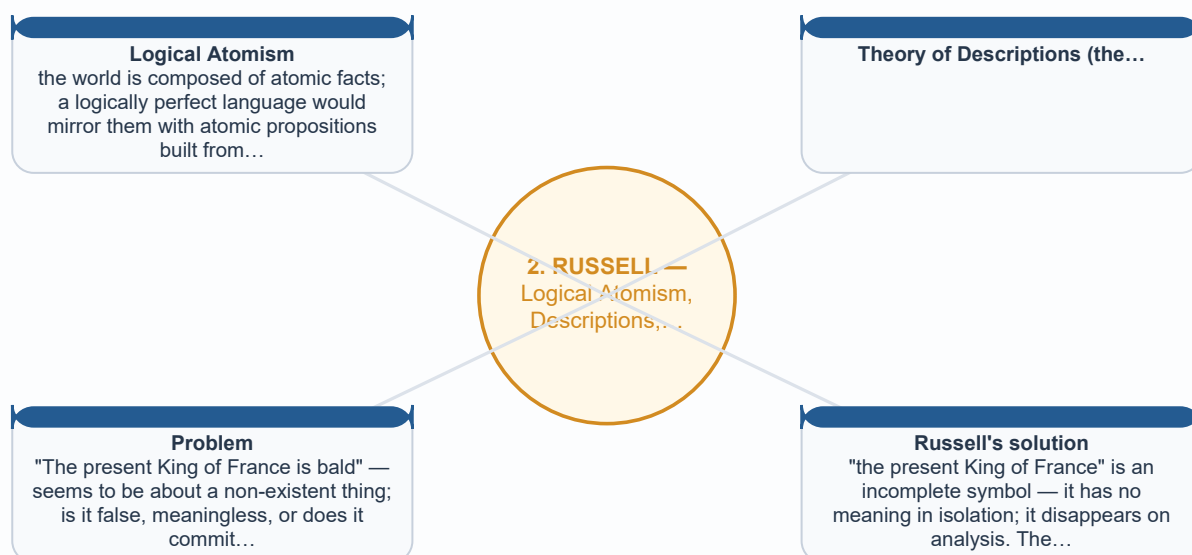
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Logical Atomism: the world is composed of atomic facts; a logically perfect language would mirror them with atomic propositions built from logically proper names + predicates. Complex propositions are truth-functions of atomic ones. Metaphysics should follow the structure of logic.

Direct local reading: Kenny, New History vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

2. RUSSELL — LOGICAL ATOMISM, DESCRIPTIONS, CONSTRUCTIONS — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE



STATIC THEORY

- Logical Atomism: the world is composed of atomic facts; a logically perfect language would mirror them with atomic propositions built from logically proper names + predicates. Complex propositions are truth-functions of atomic ones. Metaphysics should follow the structure of logic.
- Theory of Descriptions (the "paradigm of philosophy") — incomplete symbols:
- Problem: "The present King of France is bald" — seems to be about a non-existent thing; is it false, meaningless, or does it commit us to a subsistent King?
- Russell's solution: "the present King of France" is an incomplete symbol — it has no meaning in isolation; it disappears on analysis. The sentence really asserts: "There is exactly one X that is present King of France, and X is bald."
- Since no such X exists, the statement is simply FALSE (not meaningless) — no ghostly entities needed. Dissolves the puzzle without inflating ontology.
- Slogan / significance: grammatical form $\neq$ logical form; analysis reveals the true logical form hidden by surface grammar. This is the engine of analytic method.
- Logical Constructions: "Wherever possible, substitute constructions out of known entities for inferences to unknown entities." (Occam's razor applied.) E.g., a "nation," a "number," even physical objects and points of space, can be treated as logical constructions out of sense-data / classes — not extra entities we must posit.

MEMORY HOOK

CLAIM → REASON → CONSEQUENCE → OBJECTION → QUALIFIED REPLY.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Logical Atomism: the world is composed of atomic facts; a logically perfect language would mirror them with atomic propositions built from logically proper names + predicates. Complex propositions are truth-functions...
2. Theory of Descriptions (the "paradigm of philosophy") — incomplete symbols:
3. Problem: "The present King of France is bald" — seems to be about a non-existent thing; is it false, meaningless, or does it commit us to a subsistent King?
4. Russell's solution: "the present King of France" is an incomplete symbol — it has no meaning in isolation; it disappears on analysis. The sentence really asserts: "There is exactly one X that is present King of France,..."

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Moore proves each truism deductively.
- CORRECT:** He treats them as more certain than philosophical denials.
- WRONG:** A description names a special object.
- CORRECT:** Russell analyses it quantificationally as an incomplete symbol.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Kenny, *New History* vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

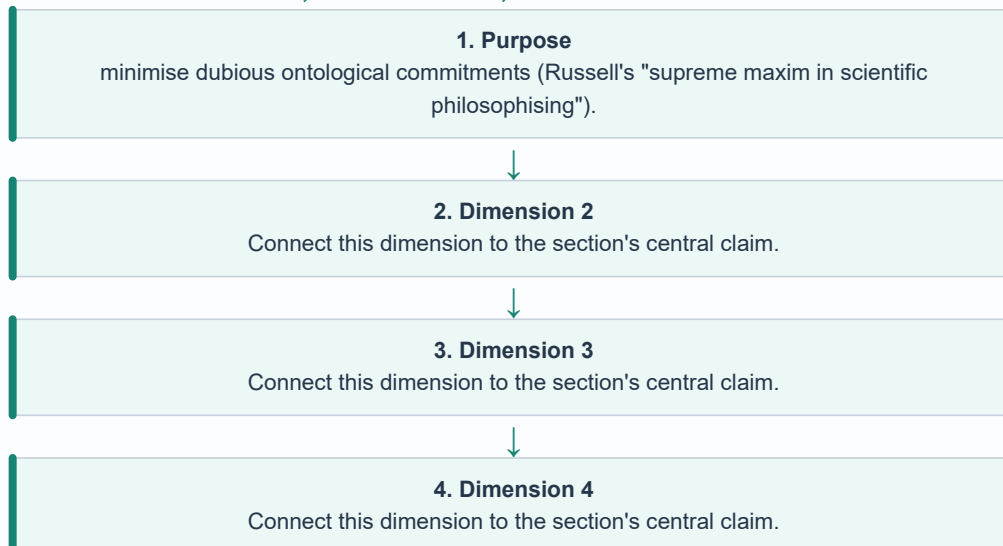
HIGH**2. RUSSELL — Logical Atomism, Descriptions, Constructions — Part 2**

Paper I Western Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Purpose: minimise dubious ontological commitments (Russell's "supreme maxim in scientific philosophising").

Continuation: preserve the full semantic chain before moving to criticism.

2. RUSSELL — LOGICAL ATOMISM, DESCRIPTIONS, CONSTRUCTIONS — REASONING SEQUENCE**STATIC THEORY**

- Purpose: minimise dubious ontological commitments (Russell's "supreme maxim in scientific philosophising").

MEMORY HOOK

M-R-W: Moore restores the world; Russell analyses it; Wittgenstein pictures its logical form.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Purpose: minimise dubious ontological commitments (Russell's "supreme maxim in scientific philosophising").

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Moore proves each truism deductively.

CORRECT: He treats them as more certain than philosophical denials.

WRONG: A description names a special object.

CORRECT: Russell analyses it quantificationally as an incomplete symbol.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Kenny, *New History* vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

HIGH**3. EARLY WITTGENSTEIN — the Tractatus — Part 1**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Picture Theory of Meaning: a proposition is a picture (logical model) of a possible fact/state of affairs. It shares a logical form with what it depicts; the arrangement of names in the proposition mirrors the arrangement of objects in the fact.

Direct local reading: Kenny, *New History* vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

3. EARLY WITTGENSTEIN — THE TRACTATUS — REASONING SEQUENCE**1. Picture Theory of Meaning**

a proposition is a picture (logical model) of a possible fact/state of affairs. It shares a logical form with what it...

**2. A proposition is meaningful**

A proposition is meaningful if it pictures a possible state of affairs; true if that state actually obtains. Names go proxy...

**3. Language–world isomorphism**

the limits of language = the limits of the world. "The world is the totality of facts, not of things."

**4. Saying vs Showing (the deepest...**

STATIC THEORY

- Picture Theory of Meaning: a proposition is a picture (logical model) of a possible fact/state of affairs. It shares a logical form with what it depicts; the arrangement of names in the proposition mirrors the arrangement of objects in the fact.
- A proposition is meaningful if it pictures a possible state of affairs; true if that state actually obtains. Names go proxy for objects; their configuration says how things stand.
- Language–world isomorphism: the limits of language = the limits of the world. "The world is the totality of facts, not of things."
- Saying vs Showing (the deepest doctrine):
- What can be said (meaningfully) = propositions of natural science (that picture facts).
- Logical form itself cannot be said — it can only be shown (displayed) by propositions. So can the mystical, ethical, aesthetic, and the metaphysical "self."
- Ethics, religion, the meaning of life are not falsehoods but lie beyond the sayable — they show themselves.

MEMORY HOOK

CLAIM → REASON → CONSEQUENCE → OBJECTION → QUALIFIED REPLY.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Picture Theory of Meaning: a proposition is a picture (logical model) of a possible fact/state of affairs. It shares a logical form with what it depicts; the arrangement of names in the proposition mirrors the...
2. A proposition is meaningful if it pictures a possible state of affairs; true if that state actually obtains. Names go proxy for objects; their configuration says how things stand.
3. Language–world isomorphism: the limits of language = the limits of the world. "The world is the totality of facts, not of things."
4. Saying vs Showing (the deepest doctrine):

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Moore proves each truism deductively.

CORRECT: He treats them as more certain than philosophical denials.

WRONG: A description names a special object.

CORRECT: Russell analyses it quantificationally as an incomplete symbol.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Kenny, *New History* vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

HIGH

3. EARLY WITTGENSTEIN — the Tractatus — Part 2

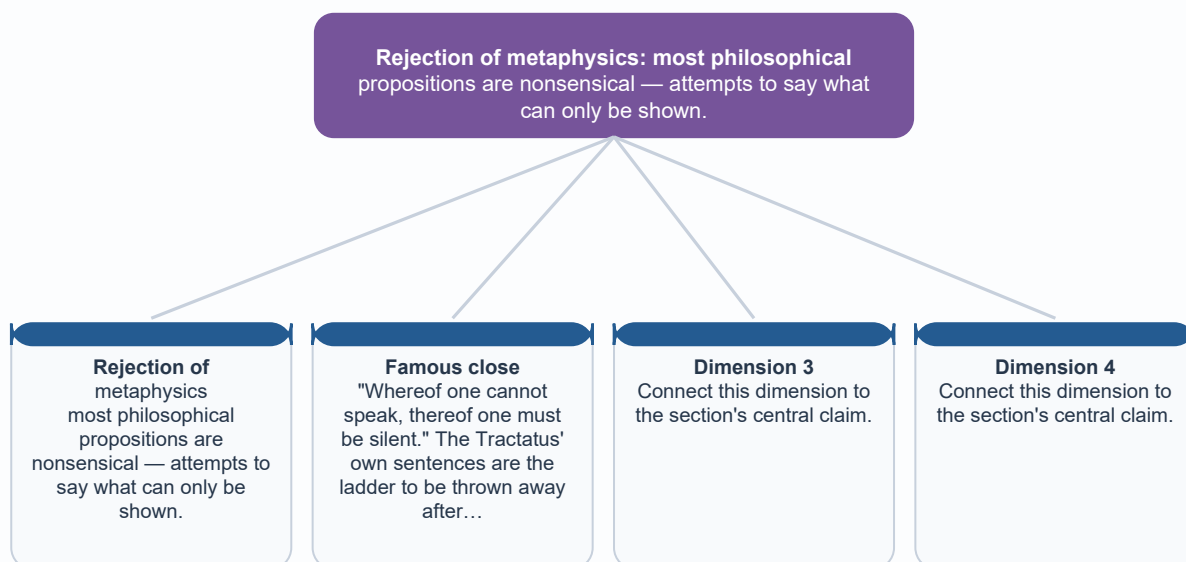
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Rejection of metaphysics: most philosophical propositions are nonsensical — attempts to say what can only be shown.

Continuation: preserve the full semantic chain before moving to criticism.

3. EARLY WITTGENSTEIN — THE TRACTATUS — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE



STATIC THEORY

- Rejection of metaphysics: most philosophical propositions are nonsensical — attempts to say what can only be shown.
- Famous close: "Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent." The Tractatus' own sentences are the ladder to be thrown away after climbing.

MEMORY HOOK

M-R-W: Moore restores the world; Russell analyses it; Wittgenstein pictures its logical form.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rejection of metaphysics: most philosophical propositions are nonsensical — attempts to say what can only be shown.
2. Famous close: "Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent." The Tractatus' own sentences are the ladder to be thrown away after climbing.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Moore proves each truism deductively.
CORRECT: He treats them as more certain than philosophical denials.
- WRONG:** A description names a special object.
CORRECT: Russell analyses it quantificationally as an incomplete symbol.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Kenny, New History vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

HIGH

Criticisms, Replies, Comparisons and Verified Statement Bank

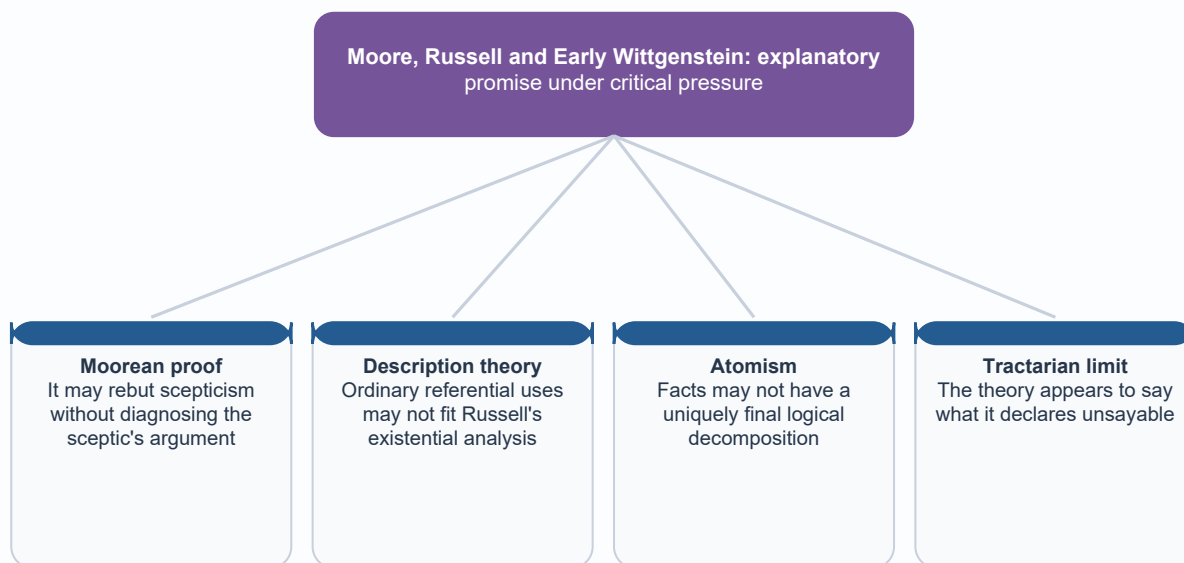
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

A high-scoring critical answer distinguishes an external rejection from an immanent objection and gives the strongest available reply before judging the doctrine.

Statement bank retained only where the verified local topic file marks the wording as canonical; all other formulations are treated as paraphrase.

CLAIM–OBJECTION–REPLY ARCHITECTURE



KEY DATA

Contribution	Moore	Russell	Early Wittgenstein
Target	idealism	metaphysical excess	limits of language
Core tool	commonsense analysis	logical analysis (descriptions)	picture theory
Ontology	realism (mind-independent objects)	logical atoms + constructions	facts, not things
Metaphysics	analyse, don't abolish	trim by constructions	most of it is nonsense (show/say)

STATIC THEORY

- **Critical pressure:** Moorean proof — It may rebut scepticism without diagnosing the sceptic's argument
- **Critical pressure:** Description theory — Ordinary referential uses may not fit Russell's existential analysis
- **Critical pressure:** Atomism — Facts may not have a uniquely final logical decomposition
- **Critical pressure:** Tractarian limit — The theory appears to say what it declares unsayable

MEMORY HOOK

C-O-R-J: CLAIM → strongest OBJECTION → plausible REPLY → reasoned JUDGEMENT.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Moore: "Here is one hand, and here is another."
2. Russell: "Wherever possible, logical constructions are to be substituted for inferred entities."
3. Russell: a definite description is "an incomplete symbol" — it has no meaning in isolation.
4. Wittgenstein: "The world is the totality of facts, not of things."
5. Wittgenstein: "Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent."

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Criticism means listing hostile names.

CORRECT: State the objection's premise, target and consequence.

WRONG: A quotation can replace exposition.

CORRECT: Unpack the statement's technical meaning and argumentative role.

WRONG: Comparison is two separate summaries.

CORRECT: Compare axis-by-axis around a shared problem.

COMPARATIVE ROUTES

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Common sense	Strawson	Both respect ordinary conceptual commitments differently
Descriptions	Strawson	Reference and presupposition challenge Russell
Picture theory	Later Wittgenstein	Ideal logical form gives way to use
Atomism	Logical positivism	Influences the analytic–synthetic and verification programme

MAINS ANGLE

Use the statement as a compressed argument: define its terms, reconstruct what follows, stage the strongest objection and give a qualified verdict.

STUDY LINK

Verified knowledge file:

Moore-Russell-EarlyWittgenstein.md • Direct local reading: Kenny, New History vol. 4, PDF pp. 65–86, 146–153 and 202–207; Warburton, PDF pp. 331–342 (Russell); Cambridge Dictionary entries on Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein.

HIGH**PYQs, Applied Drills and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Architecture**

Paper I Western Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The final layer converts doctrine into directive-sensitive answers. Keep exposition proportionate to marks, reserve space for criticism and end with a qualified philosophical judgement.

PYQs reproduced from the local UPSC Western Philosophy bank for 2022–2025; wording is shortened only in the table, not altered in doctrinal demand.

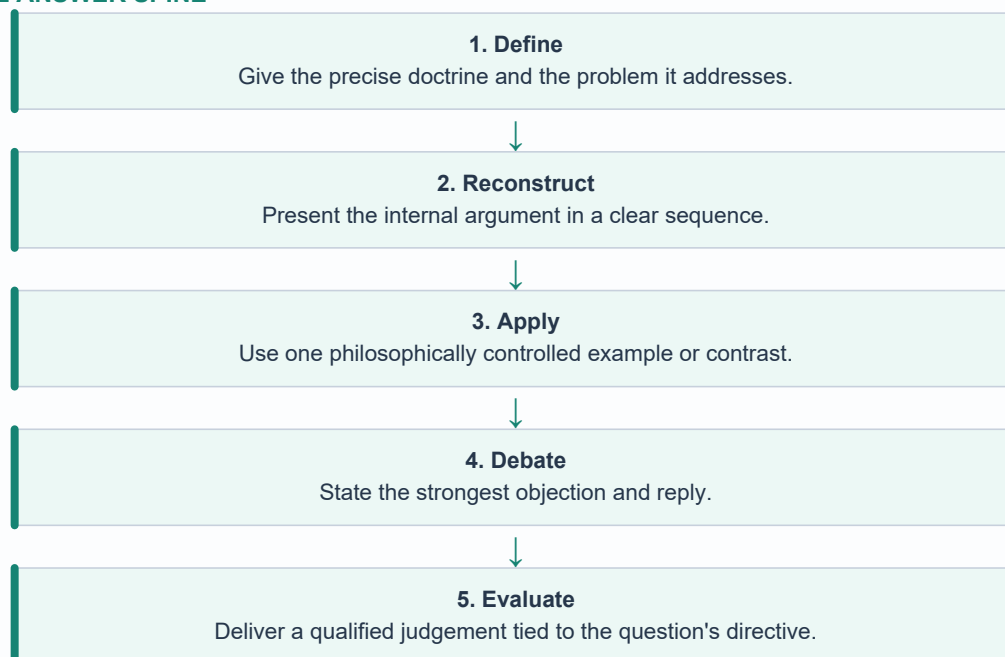
RECENT DIRECT PYQ YIELD



Bar length represents marks, not frequency.

KEY DATA

Year	Verified Demand	Marks
2025	Russell: the golden mountain and descriptions	10
2025	Moore's refutation of idealism	15
2024	Moore's common-sense truisms	10
2024	Incomplete symbols and logical atomism	20
2023	Present king of France	15
2022	Russell's logical analysis and atomic meaning	10
2022	Pictorial form, logical form and reality	15

D-R-A-D-E ANSWER SPINE**STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** 2-line context; define the key term; 3–4 linked doctrinal points; one precise objection; 2-line judgement.
- **15 marks:** establish the problem; reconstruct the argument with technical vocabulary; add comparison or example; objection–reply; balanced conclusion.
- **20 marks:** map every syllabus dimension in the question; develop the derivation; compare alternatives; stage two critical pressures; defend or qualify; conclude with an explicit criterion of success.
- [Moore] "Explain Moore's refutation of idealism and defence of commonsense."
- [Russell] "Explain Russell's theory of descriptions / incomplete symbols with the King-of-France example."
- [Constructions] "What does Russell mean by logical constructions?"
- [Wittgenstein] "Explain the picture theory of meaning and the saying/showing distinction."
- [Movement] "How did Moore, Russell and Wittgenstein turn philosophy toward the analysis of language?"
- **7.1 — "Explain Russell's Theory of Descriptions." (item 6, high-frequency)**
 - Problem : "the present King of France is bald" — non-referring description puzzle.
 - Solution: definite descriptions = incomplete symbols (no meaning in isolation).
 - Analysis: Exists x: Kx; for all y, Ky implies y=x; and Bx. Thus false, not meaningless.
 - Point : grammatical form ≠ logical form; ontology trimmed (no subsistent entities).
 - Concl : the paradigm of analytic method.
- **7.2 — "Picture theory + saying/showing." (item 6)**
 - Picture : proposition = logical picture of a possible fact; shares logical form.

MEMORY HOOK

MARKS CONTROL DEPTH: 10 = compact argument; 15 = argument + debate; 20 = complete architecture + sustained evaluation.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The directive determines emphasis: explain, examine, compare and evaluate are not interchangeable.
2. A 20-mark answer must show relations among subparts, not merely add more bullet points.
3. Use one stable example through exposition and criticism where possible.
4. Conclusions should identify what the doctrine successfully explains and what remains unresolved.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Memorise one essay for every wording.

CORRECT: Adapt the same doctrine map to the directive and marks.

WRONG: Criticism should occupy most of the answer.

CORRECT: Secure accurate exposition before proportionate evaluation.

WRONG: A conclusion merely repeats the introduction.

CORRECT: It must state a defended philosophical judgement.

MAINS ANGLE

For statement questions, treat the quotation as a claim needing reconstruction; for comparison, organise by axes; for 'does it solve' questions, state an explicit success criterion.

STUDY LINK

Official local PYQ bank:

[_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2022-2025.md](#)

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI